

Chapter 81-2

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Zhao Ling's life consisted of being bullied by Zhao Xuning and Zhao Ying on a daily basis, as well as constantly teetering on the edge of being infuriated to death by his two older sisters.

He had already gotten used to Zhao Xuning's sharp tongue, but regarding Zhao Xuning's tendency to side with outsiders over family,¹ he still held an opposing opinion.

Mainly because he felt that Zhao Xuning and Shen Hui were unlikely to work out.

"Sis." Zhao Ling thought it over again and again but still couldn't help saying, "Before, I thought she wasn't good enough for you, but now it's obvious—we're not good enough for her."

They happened to reach the restaurant entrance. As Zhao Ling pushed the door open ahead of them, he said, "I advise you to give up on this. How can a broken mirror possibly be glued back together?"

"Watch out—" Several voices rang out simultaneously, startling Zhao Ling.

He turned around and found Shen Siyan holding a food tray with a dark expression. The soup and rice in the tray had spilled, and some had splashed onto him.

Zhao Ling: "..."

Well, what a coincidence.

Liang Shi witnessed the whole thing from behind.

When Zhao Ling was opening the door, he was talking to Zhao Xuning, so he was a bit reckless. Shen Siyan had been carrying his tray just fine, but because of the unexpected turn, he almost collided with Zhao Ling. Afraid of accidentally hurting Zhao Ling, he moved the tray toward himself, which ended up getting food on his own clothes.

"Watch where you're going." Zhao Ling struck first. "There are people coming and going here. What if you bumped into someone?"

Shen Siyan was speechless, his brows furrowed tightly. "You're the one who wasn't watching where you were walking."

He had very handsome features that didn't match his name at all. His voice was also particularly cold. Especially his eye color—a light brown that looked like he was wearing colored contacts, giving his handsome face a somewhat bewitching quality.

Liang Shi glanced inside and immediately spotted Shen Hui sitting there.

Shen Hui had originally been looking down at her phone, but after hearing the commotion, she raised her head and watched silently.

Liang Shi's gaze happened to meet Shen Hui's in mid-air. She smiled and nodded, showing a friendly attitude first.

But Shen Hui had no reaction, her expression indifferent.

Only then did Liang Shi notice her eyes—very similar to Shen Siyan's, both with light brown pupils. Quite rare.

This eye color on Shen Hui's face made her appear particularly aloof and unfeeling.

Even though the midday sunlight was refracting down, illuminating her skin until it glowed, it still made her seem unapproachable.

Yet as Liang Shi looked, she inexplicably felt that their eye shape was very familiar, but she couldn't recall where else she had seen the same eyes.

Meanwhile, Shen Siyan and Zhao Ling were already at each other's throats. Both were young men in the prime of youth, each more hot-blooded than the other.

After just two sentences of disagreement, they were glaring at each other angrily.

It was Zhao Xuning who spoke up: "Zhao Ling, apologize."

Zhao Ling was surprised, his questioning tone carrying grievance: "Ning-jie?"

The single character "Ning" was dragged out with all sorts of inflections.

"Apologize." Zhao Xuning's tone was very serious, her voice cold—it was a command.

But Zhao Ling got angry. He retorted: "I won't. I didn't do anything wrong."

They were blocking the doorway. Customers behind them couldn't get in, while customers inside watched the show.

Shen Siyan glanced at him, frowning. After a moment, he said: "Forget it."

He carried his spilled soup and rice away. After sitting back down, Shen Hui handed him napkins to wipe the oil stains on his clothes.

This was a self-service restaurant with three food pickup stations. The one Shen Siyan had used was the least crowded, but because it was easy to get caught by the door, most people didn't use it.

It was nearly lunchtime, and people kept streaming in.

Because of the earlier unpleasantness, Zhao Ling talked less, but since Liang Shi was still there, he maintained basic courtesy. He went to the counter to order, got a ticket number, then came back to ask Liang Shi what she wanted to drink.

Liang Shi asked for plain water. Zhao Ling was secretly sulking at Zhao Xuning and didn't ask what she wanted, directly getting her an iced cola and shoving it over.

Zhao Xuning crossed her arms and looked at him. "Why didn't you apologize just now?"

Zhao Ling had just opened the pull-tab on the can, his finger still inside. Hearing this, he frowned: "Why should I apologize?"

"You weren't watching where you were going and bumped into him." Zhao Xuning said, "Why didn't you apologize?"

Zhao Ling: "Couldn't you have said it nicely?"

Zhao Xuning: "..."

A few seconds later, Zhao Xuning's tone softened. "Sorry."

Zhao Ling: "..."

He hadn't expected to get an apology from Zhao Xuning so easily. Zhao Ling was stunned for a moment, then his tone became a little happy. "It's fine, I forgive you."

Liang Shi watched from the side, deeply moved.

So this was what family was like?

One second they were at each other's throats in confrontation, the next second they were all smiles.

Then Zhao Ling came to verify with her, asking about what had happened earlier. Liang Shi told him truthfully.

Zhao Ling sat there thinking for a moment, then got up to find Shen Siyan.

Liang Shi sat there, holding a cup of hot water to warm her hands, steam rising before her eyes.

She watched as Zhao Ling walked righteously over to Shen Siyan's table, placed two drinks on their table, cleared his throat and called out to Shen Siyan, saying in a low voice: "I'm sorry, I was wrong earlier."

Liang Shi was shocked.

She had thought that boys this age might get into a fight, but would never apologize.

Zhao Ling had overturned her perception.

Shen Siyan's response also made her eyes light up: "It's fine now. My attitude wasn't good earlier either. Let's just let this pass."

Liang Shi: "..."

She looked at Zhao Xuning and couldn't help but exclaim: "Their families raised them so well."

Zhao Xuning raised an eyebrow, as if to say— isn't that how it should be?

After Zhao Ling returned, the atmosphere was the same as usual, continuing to chatter away. Liang Shi just listened to the lively conversation from the side.

However, while eating, Liang Shi was chatting casually with Zhao Ling when she suddenly said: "The Shen siblings' eye color is so beautiful. It looks very familiar."

Zhao Ling: "?"

He gulped down his soup and rice and looked at Liang Shi in astonishment.

Liang Shi asked: "What's wrong?"

Zhao Ling blinked and answered: "It does look familiar. Why don't you just go look in a mirror?"

Liang Shi: "...?"

What the heck?

Hearing this, Zhao Xuning also looked over. She carefully examined Liang Shi's eyes and said objectively: "They are quite similar."

Zhao Ling nodded: "I was just about to say—the eyes of you three are very similar. Mainly the pupil color. It's like you're all wearing colored contacts."

Speaking of this, Zhao Ling also told an amusing story.

When they went to take ID photos for their student cards at the start of the semester, when it was Shen Siyan's turn, the photographer told him to remove his colored contacts. Shen Siyan said he wasn't wearing any.

The photographer insisted he was and even thought he was being dishonest, getting so angry he wanted to quit.

After an examination, they discovered that Shen Siyan's natural eye color was just like that. It turned out to be a big misunderstanding, and the photographer was extremely embarrassed.

Liang Shi nodded: "That kind of trouble does happen."

Back in her original world, when she went to take her ID photo, it had been the same.

Shen Hui and Shen Siyan had arrived first and left together after finishing their meal.

Zhao Xuning kept staring at their retreating figures until they disappeared from sight.

Liang Shi and Zhao Ling exchanged glances simultaneously and shook their heads helplessly.

When it comes to matters of the heart, only those who experience it truly understand.

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1. "Side with outsiders over family" (胳膊肘往外拐) — Literally "the elbow bends outward," a Chinese idiom meaning to favor outsiders over one's own family members, implying disloyalty or putting strangers' interests above family. ⇐